

WHITE RHINOCEROS

Ceratotherium simum

Despite its unnerving appearance, this giant of the African plains is a mild-tempered vegetarian. The huge horns are used almost entirely in self-defence or for protecting the young. Adult rhinoceroses usually live alone, although they sometimes form loose groups to share feeding areas. Males are territorial and mark their territory with pungent urine and droppings. They will compete for the right to mate with a certain female, but most disputes are solved with a bout of showing off, after which the weaker male backs down. This species has suffered a drastic decline in numbers and range as a result of habitat loss and hunting.

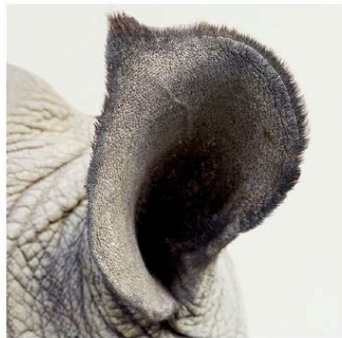
✓ SHORT SIGHTED

Rhinoceroses are somewhat short sighted. Having eyes located on the sides of the head gives them a wide field of vision, but impairs their ability to see straight ahead.



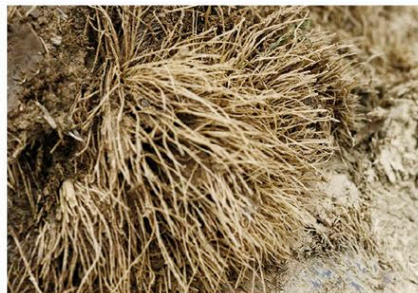
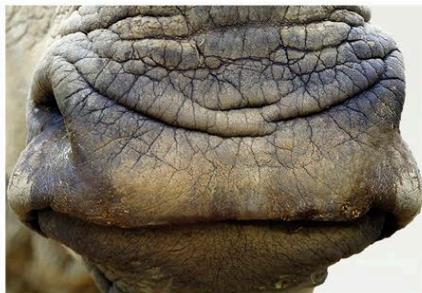
✓ HAIRY EARS

The ears are the hairiest part of a rhinoceros's body. They provide excellent hearing, and swivel to detect sounds from any direction.



WIDE MOUTH >

The white rhinoceros is the largest animal to survive on an exclusive diet of grass. Its wide, straight mouth is shaped for maximum efficiency when cropping short grass.



< HORN OF HAIR

Rhinoceros horn is made of a protein called keratin. The same substance is found in hair and nails – in fact, the rhinoceros's horn is little more than a mass of compacted hair.



front horn of a mature rhino can grow up to 1.5 m (5 ft) long

< RHINO HIDE

Despite the species' name, the tough, wrinkled skin of the white rhinoceros is grey, not white. Up to 2 cm (¾ in) thick, the skin is made up of layers of collagen, arranged in a criss-cross pattern.



< UNDERSIDE OF FOOT

The unusual shape of a rhinoceros's foot makes the animal relatively easy to track. Some experienced trackers can even recognize individual animals from their footprint.



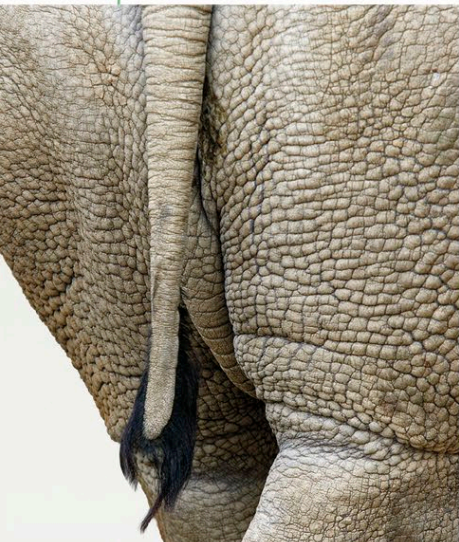
< THREE TOES

Rhinoceroses have three toes on each foot. Most of the weight is borne on the middle toe, with the smaller side toes aiding balance and grip.



^ TELLING TAIL

The short tail hangs down when the rhinoceros is relaxed and curls up like that of a pig at times of excitement, such as when mating.



SIZE 1.5–1.8 m (5–6 ft)

HABITAT Savanna grassland

DISTRIBUTION C. and S. Africa

DIET Grass



> GENTLE GIANT

White rhinoceroses suffer from an undeserved reputation for bad temper. In reality they are peace-loving, even timid, animals. Under normal circumstances they charge only when provoked or confused. The black rhinoceros is much more aggressive.